and so was my social sense, my notion of how much attention to give a person who was speaking in a way that wasn't accurate, for instance.

This was the way my mind was going at the time. My study of quantum mechanics was causing me to question the measures of pain and pleasure in my life, and how they could be balanced, or what would happen if I had more of one than the other. The broken arm was important for me – it was an analogy, almost a parable, of how to go about making and sustaining a change. That probably sounds odd. What I mean is that it made me think about the way in which single discrete events could have far-reaching consequences. When my arm broke it had to be healed – remade, in some way. I started to think about how I could begin to heal the injustices I saw around me – how one could remake the world through a political act. In this way I was arriving at a philosophy of change and I believe it influenced everything I later did. I knew you couldn't test these things in the cloistered economic unreality of the university in the long run, but the process began, for me, from that period of study in which I deepened my experience of cause and effect.

Yet, my capacity for finding things intolerable was always in evidence. Too much in evidence, perhaps. But what can you do? There was a research project in the department to study sand, because the Americans were dealing with sand as part of their adventures in the Middle East. Some woman came to give us a talk about how beautiful it had been to take part in the testing of military hardware and assisting with the flying of the cargo planes that bombed retreating Iraqi troops in the first Gulf War and created all that carnage. I thought, 'Why are we sitting here listening to this mass murderer?' I began to see how the universities were being used by people interested in military profiteering. You could see it if you went to conferences, the whole thing being underwritten by the Australian Defense Science and Technology Organisation. Everything was coming together in my head during this period: the clarity of mind that quantum mechanics forced upon me, my ideas about cause and effect, my horror at military outrages and my increasing insights into Western foreign policy. It was becoming obvious to me, during those years of studying at university, that we needed mechanisms – brand new ways – to take the fruits of science and implement them for the common good. Not for the service of particular agencies, but for truth itself. I loved studying physics, but my hatred for institutionalism only grew. I could see how spineless many of the scientists